



Kodak Easyshare C713

was tested last year. The MDC 530 was a 5 MP camera with the same features.

Although it lagged behind in quality in a majority of the tests, the zoomed photo test showed good quality. The reds in the shots weren't reproduced



Mustek MDC530

well—in the test shots, red items looked more orange than red. There were some issues with the MDC 530. It only had an ISO range between 50 and 200, whereas most cameras had a higher range—64 to 3200 in some. A low range ISO range means a camera won't have

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TECH-COM DSC-520

enough intermediate steps to switch to get the right balance between exposure and grain in a photo.

TECH-COM sent us a few of their cameras from last year's test—the DSC-524X PLUS, the DSC-520 and the DSC-601.

The DSC-601 lacked an optical zoom altogether and the macro shots and zoom shots were appalling when used with the only zoom available – digital.

The other TECH-COM's were a lot better. Although they were around 5 MP each, they performed alright.

In the DSC-524X PLUS, there was massive purple fringing visible on the bright shots. Both the cameras were easy to take macro shots with, but the details were smudgy.

The design and body wasn't as sporty and interesting as the other contenders in the group. The same was the case with the DSC-520.

The photos taken on it had jagged edges and the photos seem to be sharpened by the camera. Zoomed outdoor photos show details being blended together to create patching patterns—which is certainly not acceptable.



TECH-COM DSC-524X PLUS



TECH-COM DSC-601

Rs 10,001 to Rs 16,000

Canon PowerShot SX100 IS

Canon's PowerShot SX100 IS looked like a compact camera on steroids because of its form. It looks like any other camera, but larger. The SX100, as we've seen on previous occasions, has a mighty 10X zoom, and tries to go head-to-head with ultra zoom cameras.

The button layout is different, as is the design. They are larger, well labelled and all these details make using the interface very easy. A scrolling dial is used to browse through the controls instead of directional buttons. There is also a playback button—previewing images is easier than on a camera where you have to use a dial or a knob.

Although the unique design is great, the quality isn't as top notch as the IXUS series, for example. The scroll wheel mentioned earlier, as well as the buttons seemed a little wobbly and loose. Despite its size, it lacks an eyepiece and the flash won't pop open by itself. Manual focusing is a great feature to have in a camera like this, and the dial used to control it is accurate.

The detail and clarity in wide-angle shots and in the lit scene test shots is a tiny bit better than the other good Canon in this category—the A720 IS. The powerful lens on the SX100 shows better detail in telephoto shots. The SX100 is also better at taking macro shots. Focussing is instantaneous and you can get unbelievably close to the objects. Video quality is decent too but the colours are a bit too saturated.

A larger screen in place of the 2.5-



Canon PowerShot SX100 IS

inch one provided would be better suited to something this large. It is clearly the best of the lot, but there are a few things to keep in mind with the SX100. Its massive zoom means that there are larger mechanisms involved, and because of this the size of the camera has gone up. It isn't very comfortable to hold in your hand and cannot be shoved into a pocket. At 265 grams, it's not exactly light either.

Canon PowerShot A720 IS

The Canon PowerShot A720 IS is geared towards users who want an easy to use camera, which can on occasions be used for more advanced photography. The A720 IS is an upgrade from the previous A710, which we know was a great camera.

There have been a few upgrades since then, but the 6x zoom isn't one of them. It now sports an 8 MP sensor, and there are a few changes in the ISO ratings supported by the camera at the higher end. This should mean improved flexibility in low light scenarios.



Canon PowerShot A720 IS

Unlike the SX100, the A720 IS is a little more manageable when it comes to its bulk. The body is better built and holding it is a lot easier. The body is shaped and design to look a lot more casual and users are bound to love

the A720 design over the SX100. The use of a slider to switch to playback mode is annoying. The A720 has the manual focus feature found on the SX100 and some other Canon cameras.

In terms of quality, it is equally behind the SX100 as it is ahead of the A590 IS. Last year the A570 IS was one of the leading performers in the test. The A590 IS which is supposedly an upgrade to the A570 IS is not as impressive as expected. The A720 is pretty close to the SX100 in quality all throughout, but lags a bit behind in the zoomed test. Images turn out a little too soft losing some detail, whereas the SX100 stays sharp all throughout its 10x zoom.

For a lot less, Rs 12,995 to be precise, users can still get a very good 6x optical zoom while not having to sacrifice on a compact design and build quality. The A720 isn't lacking anything much other than the zoom on the SX100 though.

Canon Digital IXUS 80 IS

The Canon Digital IXUS 80 IS is a camera very similar to the slightly superior IXUS 85 IS. It brings along a decently built design for people on the move. There aren't too many settings and controls to play around with on this camera.



Canon Digital IXUS 80 IS

It is made for users who want a camera that's really compact to carry around—like a mobile phone of sorts.

One of the first issues is the battery door: as is the case with the IXUS 85 IS, the battery door here too feels weak and flimsy. Most of the interface design as well as the frame design is identical. The big change is in the Megapixel rating—the 80 IS is an 8 MP camera.

All the other Canon cameras in this price bracket run on AA batteries, but the IXUS 80 IS has a Lithium-ion battery. This, coupled with its compact design makes it a lot lighter than the rest. However, the shrunken size means it's no longer chunky enough to hold in your hand as easily as the PowerShot series cameras.

Its overall performance isn't bad at all. In just plain image and video quality tests, it lags behinds all the Canon cameras, but not the others. Macro shots aren't as easy to take as with the SX100 IS

or the A720 IS. In video quality, once again, colours are a little too prominent, but the exposure meter helps change the intensity of light instantly, and there's not a lot of lag in lighting correction while moving from bright areas to dimmer ones. Overall, it's a very good camera if you aren't particular about pristine quality and manual controls.

Samsung i8

The Samsung i8 is a little larger than the compact cameras from the other camera makers.